Rashmi Mukherjee knew all the old villains—maida, excess sugar and trans fats—the familiar markers of food best kept to a minimum. So, chips and packaged biscuits disappeared from her 13-year-old's diet, and in came granola bars, multigrain snacks, protein products and treats labelled 'no added sugar'. That was until the 45-year-old boutique hotel manager in Gurugram began turning the packets over. Only to find words like maltodextrin, glucose-fructose syrup, protein isolates, emulsifiers, modified starches and unfamiliar sweeteners appear on foods she had assumed were the better choice. "I never thought I would have to read every ingredient on the back," she says.

That is the first thing you should do, according to Dr Esha Wadhwa Luthra, head of the department of clinical nutrition at BLK-Max Hospital, Delhi: "Check the ingredient list for ultra-processed additives." Particularly maltodextrin, emulsifiers such as carboxymethylcellulose and polysorbate-80 and refined palm oils. The problem, Ishi Khosla, noted Delhi-based nutritionist, points to is our tendency to think, 'If it's soup, it must be healthy'. "But it is still out of a packet," she says. Look closely at the label on the back, and you may find old concerns in new forms. "The proposed FSSAI warning labels could



7 ERYTHRITOL
Sugar alcohol that tastes sweet but provides very few calories

Used in: Keto, low-carb, sugar-free foods and tabletop sweeteners

Warning: Human research found a marker linked with greater clotting potential. But whether routine intake directly causes cardiovascular disease remains unresolved. No simple universal daily consumer limit so far



8 CARBOXYMETHYLCELLULOSE—CMC/ E466
Absorbable phosphorus-containing salts, including sodium phosphates and polyphosphates

Used in: Processed cheese and meat, beverages and packaged foods to retain moisture and improve texture

Warning: Excess exposure may harm people with kidney disease. Food-specific limits apply



9 POLYSORBATE-80
Emulsifier that helps oil and water remain mixed

Used in: Sauces, desserts, ice creams and other processed foods

Warning: Human research found alterations in the gut microbial environment, although it did not show a significant rise in systemic inflammation over the study period. Category-specific FSSAI limits apply but no universal daily figure



10 CARRAGEENAN
Thickener extracted from red seaweed

Used in: Dairy drinks, plant milks, desserts, sauces and processed foods

Warning: Controlled human research found changes in intestinal permeability and the gut environment, but did not establish that carrageenan causes systemic inflammatory disease

11 SODIUM NITRITE/ NITRATE
Salts used as curing preservatives in processed meat

Used in: Smoked and cured meats, ham, bacon, sausages and some deli meats to control bacteria and preserve colour

Warning: Research links higher exposure to certain food-additive nitrites and nitrates with adverse effects. Product-specific limits apply to cured and processed meats; no single limit on all foods



12 MODIFIED STARCHES
Ordinary food starch altered to change how it behaves

Used in: Soups, sauces, frozen foods, fillings and desserts to keep them stable during storage

Warning: Studies link additive mixtures rich in modified starches and other emulsifiers/ stabilisers with higher type-2 diabetes incidence, but don't prove modified starch alone causes diabetes

